



"This is the system we run for our clients. Over 5,000 jobs booked. Over \$7 million in client revenue. 30 niches, 20 states."

Brandon Aubey, Dead River Management

THE DEAD RIVER PLAYBOOK

How to get the phone ringing with people who are already looking for what you sell. And what to do when it does.

Hey,

This isn't another guide from some marketing guy about how to set up a business page or install a pixel. There are nine thousand of those on YouTube already, and most of them are written by people who have never had to make payroll off the jobs that came in.

This is what we actually do.

This is the playbook we run inside Dead River for roofers, plumbers, auto shops, med spas, freight brokers, and about 25 other kinds of local business. It's what's behind the auto shop that went from \$20,000 a month to \$100,000, the roofer that went from 2 roofs a month to 8, and the plumber that went from \$60,000 a year to \$250,000.

I spent ten years helping local businesses get more jobs before I started Dead River. And the thing I saw over and over was good businesses paying for clicks while the phone went to voicemail. Spaghetti at the wall. A little bit of this, a little bit of that, and nothing sticks.

So here's how this is split up:

- **Part 1: The system.** How a lead turns into a paid job, and where it leaks. Numbers, your CRM, follow-up, your Google profile, your website. Boring, and it's where most of the money is.
- **Part 2: The people already looking.** How we find the people in your area who are searching for what you sell right now, before they fill out a form anywhere.
- **Part 3: The ads.** How to write a Facebook or Instagram ad somebody actually stops for, and how to set the account up so a winning ad keeps winning.
- **Part 4: Your 90 days.** What to do first, what to do next, and the worksheets.

Most owners get this backwards. They run ads before the phone gets answered. Or they fix the phone and never run an ad. The ones who win do both, in that order.

That's what this is for. Don't try to do it all at once. Pick one fix. Do it. Then the next one.

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What's in here.

Four parts. Start wherever it hurts.

Hey, 2

Part 1: The system. How a lead becomes a paid job. Fix this before you spend a dollar on ads.

Start with one fix.	5
Growth is a team sport.	6
Where do people get stuck?	7
A sale is not all profit.	8
Follow the people.	9
Know what each step costs.	10
Start with the goal.	11
Make the next step useful.	12
Show what they get.	13
Give every lead a home.	14
Five minutes. Not five hours.	15
Build a stop button.	16
Missed a call? Reach back.	17
Show them the form worked.	18
Make the visit easy.	19
Don't lose the quote.	20
No reply? Use a short plan.	21
Missed visit? Offer a reset.	22
Make your map profile clear.	23
Keep it real. Keep it current.	24
Ask for honest reviews.	25
Reply like a person.	26
Give each service its own page.	27
Make each town page useful.	28
Help search find the page.	29
Answer what people ask.	30
Use one answer three ways.	31
Help them choose you.	32
Make asking for help easy.	33
Make the call feel easy.	34
Help them compare.	35
Start with the right group.	36
Send a useful check-in.	37
The next job starts here.	38
Make plans easy to understand.	39
Connect the lead to the job.	40
Use each tool for its job.	41
Check the week. Pick one fix.	42

Part 2: The people already looking. Stop showing your ad to everybody. Show it to the ones who are searching for you right now.

Most ads go to the wrong people. 44

Where your customers are. 45

Build your list. 46

Put the list to work. 47

See who is already on your site. 48

Part 3: The ads. How to write a Facebook or Instagram ad somebody stops for, and how to set the account up so a winner keeps winning.

Stop obsessing over the algorithm.	50
Your ad is your targeting now.	51
Every ad has two jobs.	52
The anatomy of an ad that works.	53
Three things, every time.	54
Don't write headlines from a blank page.	55
Swipe the shape. Change the words.	56
Win the scroll.	57
Make the ad look like a post. Not an ad.	58
Statics first. Video second.	59
Six formats we cycle through.	60
The two lines everybody wastes.	61
Long copy wins. When it is interesting.	62
Specific is believable. Believable gets clicked.	63
"Learn more." That's the button.	64
Change one word. Open a new pocket of customers.	65
A winner is a seed. Not a finish line.	66
Match the ad to the page.	67
Structure only matters after you have a winner.	68
The settings that apply to everything.	69
Bids and budgets.	70
Retarget with a different reason. Not more pressure.	71
The launch checklist.	72
When an ad wins. When an ad dies.	73
Track the number that pays the crew.	74
The most common mistakes.	75

Part 4: Your 90 days. What to do first, what to do next, and the worksheets to do it with.

Build it in three steps.	77
Your first week.	78
Your one-fix worksheet.	79
Your numbers worksheet.	80
Your ad worksheet.	81
You have the playbook.	82

01

The system.

How a lead becomes a paid job. Fix this before you spend a dollar on ads.

YOUR STARTING POINT

Start with one fix.

You don't need to do all of this at once. Find the row that sounds like your business and go there first.

Too few calls

Get found. Parts 2 and 3, and the Google profile and website pages in this part.

Calls, but not many jobs

Handle each lead. The "fix the leads you have" pages. Start with the 5-minute rule.

Quotes go out and nobody replies

Help people choose. The "win the job" pages.

Not much repeat work

Stay in touch. The "bring people back" and "keep good customers" pages.

Not sure what's working

Track the job. The "track the job" pages, then the weekly check.

A lead is anybody who asks about work. Words in {braces} are blanks for you to fill in. Any made-up numbers on these pages are marked as an example. They are not Dead River results.

DO THIS NOW Pick the row that sounds like your business.

01 / THE GROWTH SYSTEM

Growth is a team sport.

Every step needs a clear next step, and somebody who owns it.

1

Get found

The people already looking for you, search, maps, and ads that go to the right people.

2

Get the lead

A clear page and an easy way to call or ask.

3

Win the job

Reply in 5 minutes, book the visit, quote it, close it.

4

Do great work

Finish, check in, ask for the review.

5

Grow again

Stay in touch, track it, fix what broke, then scale.

If one step is broken, fix it before you send more people through it. Spending more on ads to feed a phone nobody answers is just a faster way to lose money.

DO THIS NOW

Put a name next to each handoff. One person owns it.

01 / THE GROWTH SYSTEM

Where do people get stuck?

Pull up your last ten leads. If you've got fewer, use all of them.

CHECK	OK	FIX	?
Can people find us? Search, maps, and the ads. Where did these ten actually come from?	☐	☐	☐
Can they reach us? Call your own number. Fill out your own form. Try the chat.	☐	☐	☐
Did we get back to them in 5 minutes? Look at missed calls and forms that sat.	☐	☐	☐
Did they book and buy? Visits, quotes, and the jobs we lost.	☐	☐	☐
Did they come back? Reviews, reminders, repeat work.	☐	☐	☐

Mark each row works, needs work, or not sure. A broken phone or form gets fixed first, before anything else on this list.

DO THIS NOW Circle one weak spot. That is your first fix.

02 / KNOW YOUR NUMBERS

A sale is not all profit.

You still have to pay for the work, and for the next job.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

\$600

Direct cost of doing the work. Crew, materials, fuel.

\$100

What it cost to win the job. Ads, the person answering the phone.

\$300

What's left for the bills and for you.

That's a \$1,000 job. The \$300 still has to help pay the rent, the truck, and the insurance. Track taxes, refunds, and card fees the same way every time so the number means the same thing every month.

This is the first thing we go over on a call with a new client, before anybody talks about price. What's a customer worth to you, and what's your average ticket. If you don't know those two numbers, you can't know what a lead is worth, and you'll either overpay for leads or walk away from good ones.

DO THIS NOW Check the real costs on one finished job.

02 / KNOW YOUR NUMBERS

Follow the people.

A reply, a booking, and a paid job are three different things.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE



Painting example. Two of the sold jobs aren't done yet, so don't count their quotes as money collected. The place the numbers drop the hardest is the place to fix first.

DO THIS NOW Count each step for one group of past leads.

02 / KNOW YOUR NUMBERS

Know what each step costs.

Same spend, same group of leads, all the way through.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

COST PER LEAD	$\$6,000 \div 100 \text{ leads}$	\$60
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COST PER BOOKING	$\$6,000 \div 50 \text{ booked}$	\$120
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COST PER NEW CUSTOMER	$\$6,000 \div 16 \text{ paid jobs}$	\$375
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This uses everything it cost to win those customers, not just the ad spend. Each of the 16 finished jobs is a new customer. Ad spend alone is a different number, and it's the one most agencies will show you because it looks better.

Cheap leads can cost more. Thirty leads at \$17 each that turn into one job cost you more than fifteen leads at \$40 that turn into six. Always run it through to the paid job.

DO THIS NOW Fill in your cost per lead, per booking, and per new customer.

02 / KNOW YOUR NUMBERS

Start with the goal.

Then work backwards to the leads and the budget.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Revenue goal	\$60,000
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At \$3,000 a job	20 jobs
------------------	----------------

If half of the quotes sell	40 quotes
----------------------------	------------------

If 4 in 5 visits get a quote	50 booked
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If half of the people you reach book	100 reached
--------------------------------------	--------------------

If you reach 4 in 5	125 leads
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At \$40 a lead, that's \$5,000 in ad spend. Add tools, fees, and the time of whoever's selling. Then check your crew has the room to do 20 jobs and you can wait to get paid on them. This is a plan, not a forecast.

This is also why our guarantee needs \$3,000 a month in ad spend to work. Under that, the math doesn't get to \$50,000 in 60 days for most businesses.

DO THIS NOW Run it with your own job value and your own past rates.

03 / THE OFFER

Make the next step useful.

Tell people exactly what they get when they ask for help.

WHO	Who needs this work? A homeowner with a leak. A fleet manager with 12 trucks. A woman who wants her skin fixed before a wedding.
PROBLEM	What do they need fixed, in their words, not yours?
OFFER	What will you do first? An inspection, a consult, a quote, a same-week visit.
PROOF	Real facts that build trust. Jobs done, years in business, real reviews, real photos.
TERMS	What costs extra? What's not included? Say it before they ask.
NEXT STEP	Call, text, request a visit, or get a quote. Pick one and make it obvious.

Add real timing, real service area, and real price terms. Only use guarantees and payment plans you can actually back up. Don't call a visit free if any part of it has a fee.

DO THIS NOW Write one clear offer for one service.

03 / THE OFFER

Show what they get.

A clear scope helps people choose you over the guy with the lower number.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

ROOFING

A roof check

Photos, what we found, and a repair or replace option with a price on each.

AUTO REPAIR

A diagnostic with a written estimate

What's wrong, what it costs to fix, what can wait.

MED SPA

A consult with a plan

What you want fixed, which treatment, how many sessions, and the total.

PLUMBING

A drain clearing

What's included, what it costs if we find something bigger, and when we can be there.

These are sample offers to show the shape, not Dead River results. The point is the same in every niche. A vague offer gets compared on price. A clear one gets compared on what's included, and you win that comparison.

DO THIS NOW Replace one vague offer with a list of what it actually includes.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Give every lead a home.

Your CRM is your lead list. It's what keeps a job from getting lost in somebody's text messages.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Source

Where they came from. Google, Facebook, referral, the truck.

Owner

Who's helping them. One name, not "the office."

Status

New, in contact, booked, quoted, won, lost, done, paid.

Next task

What happens next, and when. Every open lead has one.

Last contact

When you last actually spoke to them.

Visit and value

The date and what you expect the job to be worth.

Keep sold, finished, and paid as separate steps. Save the reason when you lose one. Three months from now, the reasons are the most useful thing in the whole system.

This is also the one condition people push back on with our guarantee, and it's the one we won't drop. If every lead isn't logged, we can't both look at the same numbers, and then the guarantee is just an argument waiting to happen.

DO THIS NOW Give every open lead one owner and one dated next task.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Five minutes. Not five hours.

A lead that gets a call back in 5 minutes books. A lead that gets a call back tomorrow already hired the other guy.

1

New lead

Check for spam, repeats, and whether it's work you actually do.

2

Ready to help

Assign an owner. Alert the team. The alert goes to a phone, not an inbox.

3

First reply, inside 5 minutes

A real person calls or texts. Say what happens next.

4

Human check

Did a person actually try to reach them on time? If not, the backup gets alerted.

An auto-reply is not a conversation. It buys you a minute, it doesn't buy you the job. Only promise a response time your team can actually hit, and then hit it.

Speed to lead is a must with us. It's written into the guarantee because it's the single biggest thing we've seen separate the shops that grow from the ones that say "ads don't work."

DO THIS NOW

Send yourself a test lead. Time how long it takes a human to respond.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Build a stop button.

The next message should fit what the person just did.

THEY REPLY

Stop the automated chase. A person takes over.

THEY BOOK

Stop the lead messages. Send the visit details.

THEY BUY

Move them to the job and the aftercare.

THEY SAY STOP

Stop that channel. Save the choice. Don't make them say it twice.

**WRONG PERSON OR
FAILED SEND**

Stop. Fix the record or close it.

Check the record before every send. That includes when somebody books by phone or pays some other way. Nothing kills trust faster than a "still need help?" text the day after they paid you.

DO THIS NOW

Test every branch before you turn a workflow on.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Missed a call? Reach back.

Call back the second your team can. In the meantime, the text goes out.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Hey {first_name}, this is {name} at {business}.
Sorry we missed your call. What do you need
done, and what's the ZIP code? Reply STOP to
stop texts.

1

Check the number and the text permission.

2

Send it once. Then make a real callback.

3

If they reply, a person takes over.

Skip spam, wrong numbers, and repeats. Don't promise an open slot you haven't checked.

DO THIS NOW

Give missed calls a callback task and a backup owner.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Show them the form worked.

Say you got it. Don't invent a booking.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Subject: Your {service} request

Hey {first_name}, we got your request. I'm {name} at {business}. We'll {next_step} by {real_time}. You can reply here or call {phone}.

1

Save the source and what they asked for.

2

Assign one person to follow up.

3

Check the reply and failed-send routes actually work.

Only use a time you can meet. A request is not a confirmed visit. Keep the marketing sign-up separate from the request if you need to.

DO THIS NOW**Send one test form from your site all the way to your lead list.**

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Make the visit easy.

People should know when, where, and what it costs before you show up.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

WHEN {date}, {arrival_window}, {time_zone}

WHERE {service_address}

WHAT {visit_scope} and {fee_or_terms}

ACCESS {gate, pet, or entry needs}

{business}: Your {service} visit is set for {date}, {window}. Please {access_step}. Need a different time? Call {phone}. Reply STOP to stop texts.

Remind them the day before and again close to the visit. Kill the old reminders if the time changes or the visit gets canceled.

DO THIS NOW Send the visit details and an easy way to change the time.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Don't lose the quote.

A quote you sent still needs a next step. Most of them die in an inbox.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Send

Explain the work, the price, and what's left out.

Agree

Ask when they plan to decide. Write it down.

Follow up

Use that date. Answer the next question.

Hey {first_name}, did the {service} quote come through okay? Happy to walk you through what's included. Would {time} work? {name}, {business}.
Reply STOP to stop texts.

If they accept, decline, or ask you to stop, change the plan. No fake deadlines to push the sale. If the price is only good until Friday, it's because of something real, like material costs.

DO THIS NOW Ask every quoted lead when they want to go over it with you.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

No reply? Use a short plan.

Keep each touch useful. Don't send forever.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

1

First day

Try to reach them. Give a clear next step.

2

Next business day

Try once more if it's still allowed and still useful.

3

A few days later

Ask if they still need help, then close the loop.

Hey {first_name}, do you still need help with {service}? If now's not a good time, just let me know and I'll stop messaging you. {business}, {phone}.

A reply, a booking, a sale, a no, or a stop changes this plan. Longer-term tips and seasonal check-ins need their own permission and a real reason.

DO THIS NOW

Set a limit and a stop rule for leads that never answer.

04 / FIX THE LEADS YOU HAVE

Missed visit? Offer a reset.

Find out what happened before you write someone off as a no-show.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Hey {first_name}, this is {name} at {business}. We couldn't get the visit done today. Want to set a new time, or has the plan changed? Reply STOP to stop texts.

1 Check for a delay, a change, or a canceled visit on your side first.

2 Offer real open times if they still need help.

3 Save the result and stop the old reminders.

If there was a service problem, hand it to a person to fix. Never send a sales message to somebody who's waiting on you to make something right.

DO THIS NOW Create a same-day recovery task for missed visits.

05 / GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE

Make your map profile clear.

For a local business, this is the front door. Most people see it before they see your website.

NAME	Your real business name. Not "Best Roofer El Paso Cheap."
CATEGORY	The closest match for your main work. Secondary categories for the rest.
AREA	The places you actually serve. Not the whole state.
HOURS	When a customer can actually reach a human.
LINKS	Phone, website, and a booking link that works.
PHOTOS	Real photos of real work. Your truck, your crew, a finished job. Not stock.

List your real services. Write a plain description. Keep the name, phone, and address the same across your site and every profile. Google notices when they don't match.

DO THIS NOW Check your name, phone, hours, and website on the profile today.

05 / GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE

Keep it real. Keep it current.

Wrong details cost you calls. Fake details can get the whole profile pulled.

CHECK	OK	FIX	?
Use the real name. No extra keywords, no fake towns.	☐	☐	☐
Use real locations. No made-up office, no second listing for the same shop.	☐	☐	☐
Check the address rules. Hide a home address if customers don't come to you.	☐	☐	☐
Keep hours and photos fresh. Show real work, with permission.	☐	☐	☐
Test the links. Calls and booking requests have to reach your team.	☐	☐	☐

Nobody can promise you the top map spot. Anybody who does is selling something. What you can control is being complete, accurate, reviewed, and active.

DO THIS NOW Set a monthly reminder to check the profile.

06 / REVIEWS

Ask for honest reviews.

Every real customer gets the same ask. The ones who leave a review are the ones who were asked.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Hey {first_name}, thanks for going with {business}. Would you mind leaving an honest review? {review_link}. Good or bad, it helps us. If anything's not right, call me at {phone}. Reply STOP to stop texts.

DO

Ask right after the job, while they're happy. Make it one tap. Use your review link or a QR code on the invoice.

SKIP

Gifts for reviews, fake reviews, pressure, and only sending the happy people to Google. All of it can get you flagged.

Use a channel you have permission for. One reminder is plenty. Stop on a review, a stop reply, or a failed delivery.

DO THIS NOW

Add a plain review request to the end of every job.

06 / REVIEWS

Reply like a person.

Thank people. Take care of the problem. Everybody reading the reviews is watching how you handle the bad one.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

POSITIVE REVIEW

Thanks for taking the time to write that. Glad we could get the {service} handled for you. {business}

SERVICE CONCERN

I'm sorry to hear that, and I want to make it right. Please call me, {name}, at {phone_or_email} so I can look at what happened and fix it.

If you messed up, say so. "I messed up, here's what happened, here's how we're fixing it." People trust that a lot more than a defensive paragraph. Keep private details out of the reply. Never make fixing the problem conditional on them changing the review.

DO THIS NOW Read your last ten reviews. Find one thing the team can do better.

07 / LOCAL SEARCH

Give each service its own page.

Search engines rank pages, not businesses. One page for "plumbing" loses to one page per thing you fix.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

TITLE	Water heater replacement in {city}
SCOPE	Removal, the new unit, permits, haul-away, what's not included.
COST	What changes the price. Tank or tankless, access, gas or electric.
PROOF	Real jobs, real photos, real reviews about this service.
NEXT STEP	Call or request a visit. One button, easy to find on a phone.

Answer the questions people actually ask. Link related pages to each other. Clear headings, a useful description, and it has to work on a phone, because that's where most of your customers are reading it.

DO THIS NOW Build or fix one page for your best service.

Make each town page useful.

Swapping the city name on the same page is not a town page. Google knows, and so does the person reading it.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

THIN PAGE

Same text, different city name.

Claims an office that isn't there.

No real jobs from that area.

USEFUL PAGE

Shows the real area you serve and how far out you go.

Explains local timing, permits, HOA stuff, whatever's actually different there.

Real work and real questions from that town.

Don't invent jobs or offices. If two pages are doing the same job, one strong page beats two weak ones.

DO THIS NOW Open one town page. Add a real reason for it to exist, or merge it.

Help search find the page.

Good content still has to be easy to open and easy to use.

1

Test the page

Does it load fast on a phone? Do the links and the form work?

2

Check search access

Use Search Console to inspect the page. It's free.

3

Link it

Add a link from a related page people already visit.

4

Keep it useful

Fix old facts. Merge weak repeat pages carefully.

Search Console is Google's free site-check tool. Have whoever runs your website check indexing, the sitemap, and the page code once a quarter.

DO THIS NOW

Open your main service page on your phone right now.

Answer what people ask.

Clear answers help people, help Google, and help the AI tools that more and more people are asking instead of Google.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

How much is a new water heater?

It depends on the unit, the access, and the work needed. Ask if removal, parts, permits, and any changes to the home are in the quote. Most of our jobs land between {low} and {high}.

ASK

Get the answer from the person who actually does the work.

WRITE

Short answer first. Then what changes it.

CHECK

Real facts only. Show what could change the answer.

Add local prices only when you can back them up. Clear content helps you get found. Nobody can promise you an AI mention or a ranking.

DO THIS NOW

Write down the five questions your customers ask most.

Use one answer three ways.

You don't need to post everywhere. You need one good answer in three places.

Website

The clear answer with the next step under it.

Short video

You or a tech explaining it in plain words. Phone camera is fine. Better, actually.

Follow-up

Send it when a customer asks the same thing by text.

Questions to try

Should I fix or replace my AC?

Why is my AC not cooling?

How long does a roof last here?

How many sessions until I see a difference?

Use AI to help you draft. Don't let it invent facts. Somebody who does the work checks the answer before it goes up.

DO THIS NOW Pick one question. Make it a page and a 60-second clip.

09 / YOUR WEBSITE

Help them choose you.

The page has to match the promise that brought them there. Same words, same offer.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

TOP	The service, the area, and the next step. Visible without scrolling.
PROOF	Real facts that build trust. Years, jobs, reviews, photos.
PROBLEM	What the customer is dealing with, in their words.
SOLUTION	What the service includes.
PROCESS	How the job will go, step by step.
REVIEWS	Real customer feedback, with names.
QUESTIONS	Fees, timing, and the terms people ask about.
NEXT STEP	Call or a short form. Again. People scroll.

Put a working phone link where it's easy to hit with a thumb. Show only real licenses, terms, and payment plans.

DO THIS NOW Click one of your own ads. Does the page promise the same thing the ad did?

09 / YOUR WEBSITE

Make asking for help easy.

A short form collects what the team needs for the next step. Nothing more.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Request a quote

Name

Phone

ZIP code

What do you need done?

Send request

1 Ask only what helps you route the job.

2 Show that the request went through, and say who will reply and when.

3 If you use chat, and it's AI, say so. Never let it invent a price or an open slot.

DO THIS NOW Fill out your own form on your phone. Time how long until a human replies.

10 / WIN THE JOB

Make the call feel easy.

Listen first. Then guide them to the next step.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

1

Welcome

"Thanks for calling {business}, this is {name}. What's going on?"

2

Check fit

"What do you need done, and what's the ZIP?"

3

Explain

"The visit includes {scope}. The fee or terms are {terms}."

4

Book

"I've got {real_slots}. Which one works for you?"

Confirm the address, the access, the date, and the arrival window. If you can't help, say so and point them somewhere. Don't promise a time that isn't open.

Whoever answers your phone is your most expensive salesperson. Practice this with them, and listen to a few recorded calls a month.

DO THIS NOW

Run this script with the person who answers your calls.

10 / WIN THE JOB

Help them compare.

A calm question beats pressure every time.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

"The price is too high."

"Is it over your budget, or over another quote? Let's compare what's included, because that's usually where the gap is."

"We need to think about it."

"Of course. What would help you decide, the scope, the timing, or the price?"

"We're getting a few quotes."

"That makes sense. I'll send over our scope and terms so you're comparing the same thing."

Agree on a follow-up time. Save the reason if they don't buy. Don't shame them, and don't make up urgency.

DO THIS NOW Ask one calm question before you defend the price.

11 / BRING PEOPLE BACK

Start with the right group.

Old records need a check before a new message goes out.

Old quotes

Ask if the project is still planned. Half of them are.

Past customers

Offer a service they're due for. Filter change, tune-up, touch-up.

Missed visits

Offer a new time if it's still useful to them.

Seasonal work

Ask about the next job the season brings.

Remove wrong numbers, opt-outs, and duplicates. Check you have permission for the channel. Skip anybody with an active job or an open complaint. Don't blast the whole list, pick a group with a real reason to hear from you.

DO THIS NOW Pick one small group with a real reason to hear from you.

11 / BRING PEOPLE BACK

Send a useful check-in.

A specific reason beats a vague sales push.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Hey {first_name}, this is {name} at {business}. Are you planning a {seasonal_job} this year? We can quote {real_scope}. Want me to come take a look? Reply STOP to stop texts.

Yes

Ask about the work and offer real times.

Later

Save the date they give you. Come back then.

No or stop

Close the task or stop messages.

For old quotes, ask if the work is still needed first. Confirm the current scope and price before you send a number.

DO THIS NOW

Try one small group first. Track replies, jobs, and what it cost.

12 / KEEP GOOD CUSTOMERS

The next job starts here.

Good follow-through gives people a reason to come back and a reason to tell somebody.

1

Finish well

Explain the work and what to do to take care of it.

2

Check in

A day or two later. Make sure it's right.

3

Ask for the review

Honest feedback, one tap.

4

Remind

A real service need, on a channel you're allowed to use.

5

Earn the next job

A plan, a related service, or a referral link.

Handle service issues first. Offer extra work only when it fits. Don't add somebody's friend to a text list because they got referred.

DO THIS NOW

Put the next useful service date on every customer record.

12 / KEEP GOOD CUSTOMERS

Make plans easy to understand.

A maintenance plan has to work for the customer and for your crew.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

WHAT	List the work and what's not included.
WHEN	Visit count and the schedule.
PRICE	Fees, renewal, and how to cancel.
DELIVERY	Make sure the crew can actually do the visits.

\$1,800

Yearly plan revenue

\$1,200

Service and care costs

\$600

Left before sales costs and fixed bills

Pool service teaching example. Track visits used, repeat work, and who leaves. Future payments are not cash in the bank yet.

DO THIS NOW Write the tasks, dates, price, and terms before you sell a plan.

13 / TRACK THE JOB

Connect the lead to the job.

One job ID from the first call to the paid invoice. Otherwise you are guessing which ads work.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

1

Source

Search, map, ad, referral, or other.

2

Lead

Job ID, source, owner.

3

Visit and quote

What happened and what comes next.

4

Finished job

Work done and the direct costs.

5

Paid invoice

Money received, less any refund.

Keep repeat requests about the same job together. A click, a form, and a call can all be one lead. Two ad platforms will both claim the same sale. Your job records are the referee.

DO THIS NOW Pick one finished job. Trace it back to where it came from.

13 / TRACK THE JOB

Use each tool for its job.

Your job and payment records show what the business actually earned. Everything else is a clue.

GA4 What people do on your site.

SEARCH CONSOLE How people find your site on Google.

CALL AND FORM TRACKING Which path brought the request.

CRM AND JOB RECORDS Who booked, bought, and finished.

PAYMENT RECORDS What got paid and what it cost.

Use tagged links (UTMs) to label where traffic came from. Keep names, emails, and phone numbers out of ordinary analytics fields and page URLs.

DO THIS NOW Check that one test form reaches tracking and your CRM, once.

14 / CHECK AND IMPROVE

Check the week. Pick one fix.

Look at the business numbers, then decide what to do. Not the other way around.

New leads

People reached in 5 minutes

Visits booked and kept

Quotes sent and won

Jobs finished

Money collected

Work plus marketing costs

Cost per paid job

What brought good jobs?

Where did people get stuck?

What one change is next?

Give recent leads time to turn into jobs. Don't compare an unfinished week with a finished one. Count repeat customers separately.

DO THIS NOW Write one next action, one owner, and one due date. Every week.

02

The people already looking.

Stop showing your ad to everybody. Show it to the ones who are searching for you right now.

15 / BUYING SIGNALS

Most ads go to the wrong people.

That is the whole problem with "ads don't work for my business."

Here's what I'd tell you on a call. We're a marketing agency, but we're a little bit different, because we start with who's looking, not with the ad.

Most agencies pick an audience by checking boxes. Homeowners, 35 to 65, within 25 miles. Then they put an ad in front of all of them and hope the one guy whose water heater just died happens to be scrolling.

That's throwing spaghetti at the wall and seeing what sticks. Sometimes it sticks. Mostly it doesn't, and you pay for every throw.

What we do instead is look at what people are actually looking up. Somebody in your city has been reading about water heater prices for the last two days. Somebody else just looked up three roofers. Somebody else is comparing med spas and reading reviews. Those are buying signals. They're what a person does right before they call somebody.

Demand Intelligence is the tool we built to find those people. It watches recent search and browsing activity across 280 million U.S. consumer profiles, about 60 billion behaviors a week, and it updates every day. You tell it the topics and the area. It gives you the list of people in your market who are looking right now.

Then your ads, your emails, and your calls go to that list. Not to everybody.

A buying signal means somebody recently looked up a topic, product, or service like yours. It does not mean they are certain to buy, or that they will buy today. It means they are a lot closer than the random homeowner down the street.

DO THIS NOW

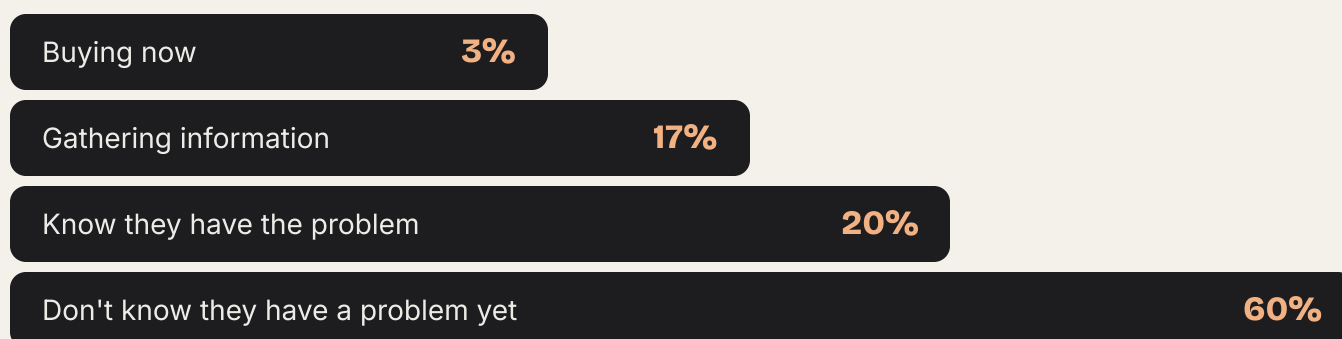
Write down the five things a customer looks up right before they call you.

15 / BUYING SIGNALS

Where your customers are.

An old sales rule, and it still holds. In any market, the buyers break down about like this.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE



Most advertisers fight over the 3%. Everybody's bidding on "emergency plumber near me." It's expensive, and you're one of eight trucks on the same search.

The 17% and the 20% are where the money is for a local business. They're reading, comparing, asking a neighbor. Nobody's talking to them yet. Buying signals tell you who they are, so you can get in front of them with something useful before they ever type "near me."

You're not just hunting the 3%. You're farming the 97%. And you're doing it with a list, not a guess.

The percentages are a rule of thumb from an old sales book, not a measurement of your market. The shape is what matters.

DO THIS NOW Look at your last ten jobs. How many called you in an emergency, and how many had been thinking about it for weeks?

16 / BUILD THE LIST

Build your list.

Four steps. You can do this yourself with the software, or we do it for you.

1

Pick the topics

What people look up before they buy from you. "Roof replacement cost." "Botox near me." "Freight broker for LTL." Be specific.

2

Pick the area and the window

Your real service area. Then how recent: the last two days for hot, the last seven for warm.

3

Add the filters that matter

Homeowner or renter. Business size. Income range. Whatever actually changes whether they're a fit for you.

4

Pull the list

Names, contact details, and what they were looking at. Contact details come back about 95% accurate.

The list changes every day, because people start looking and stop looking every day. Pull it fresh each week at least. The guy who was researching roofers two weeks ago has probably hired somebody by now.

DO THIS NOW

Write your three topics, your area, and your window.

16 / BUILD THE LIST

Put the list to work.

A list is worth nothing in a spreadsheet. Three ways we use it.

Ads

Upload the list to Meta and Google as a custom audience. Your ads only show to people who are already looking. Same budget, a lot more calls. Part 3 is how to write the ad.

Email

A short, plain email to the people on the list. Not a newsletter. One useful thing, one next step. The software writes it for you in your voice, and you approve it.

Calls and texts

For higher-ticket work. A quick "Hey, is this {first name}?" then a real conversation. Permission rules apply, and you follow them.

What it looks like for a client

A Dallas roofer wants more replacement jobs, not patches. We pull everybody in his service area who looked up roof replacement in the last seven days. His ads run only to that list. The email goes out to the ones with an address on file. His office calls the five hottest ones each morning. Every lead gets a call back inside five minutes, logged in the CRM.

That's the whole Demand Flow system. Find the people looking, get them to call, pick up fast, write it all down.

Follow the rules for texting and calling in your state. Use the list for people who are a fit for the work you actually do. Buying signals are not a promise that any one person will buy.

DO THIS NOW Pick one of the three. Run it for one service for two weeks.

16 / BUILD THE LIST

See who is already on your site.

Most of the people who visit your website never call. Now you can know who they were.

Demand Intelligence can match the people visiting your website to real profiles. Somebody reads your water heater page at 9pm and leaves. The next morning, they're on your list with a name and contact details.

1

Add the tag to your site

One snippet of code. Whoever manages your website can do it in ten minutes.

2

Watch who shows up

Which page they read, how long they stayed, and whether they came back.

3

Follow up like a person

A short email or a retargeting ad about the thing they read. Not "we noticed you visited our site." Just the useful next step.

Put this together with the list from the last page and you've got two groups: people looking around your market, and people who already looked at you. Both are a lot warmer than a cold audience.

DO THIS NOW

Count last month's website visitors. Then count the calls. The gap is the opportunity.

03

The ads.

How to write a Facebook or Instagram ad somebody stops for, and how to set the account up so a winner keeps winning.

17 / THE ALGORITHM TRAP

Stop obsessing over the algorithm.

The biggest mistake we see with owners running their own ads. They think the edge is in the settings.

They believe the win is in their targeting, their account structure, their bidding, and whatever "hack" some guy posted at 2am. Those guys are selling courses. They make it sound complicated on purpose, because the more confusing it sounds, the more the \$1,997 price tag feels justified.

DON'T OBSESS OVER

Targeting. Lookalikes. Bid settings. The newest hack.

OBSESS OVER

People. What makes somebody stop scrolling, and what gets them to call.

Here's why. You can have the cleanest account setup on the planet running an ad that's flat, boring, and looks like every other roofer's ad, and it will get beat every time by a guy with a messy account and one ad that makes people stop.

The ad is the lever. Everything else is the fulcrum.

Whatever you learn about the technical side today has a shelf life of about a year. The interface changes. The buttons get renamed. What makes a person stop and look at a picture of a roof doesn't change. Learn that, and you're set for as long as you own the business.

DO THIS NOW If you take one thing from this part, take that.

18 / HOW META PICKS ADS

Your ad is your targeting now.

Meta reads the ad itself to decide who sees it. That changes everything about how you write one.

Here's how it works, in plain words. Somebody opens Facebook or Instagram. Meta has tens of millions of ads in a pile. Its system sorts that pile in a fraction of a second and picks a short list that might fit this one person. Then it picks the winners off that short list.

The part that matters to you: it reads your picture, your headline, your copy, and your offer, and matches all of that against what it knows about each person. The ad with a photo of a shingled roof and the words "roof replacement in Dallas" gets shown to people whose behavior looks like they're thinking about a roof.

So the words and the picture you put in the ad are the audience signal you're sending. Whoever you describe in the ad is who Meta goes looking for.

This is also why the list from Part 2 and a good ad work so well together. The list tells Meta who's looking. The ad tells Meta what they're looking for. You've stacked two signals that most advertisers don't have.

It also means Meta rewards fresh variety. It can handle a lot of new ads without slowing down, and it gets tired of the same one fast. We'll come back to that.

DO THIS NOW Read your current ad. Who, exactly, does it describe? If the answer is "anybody," that is the problem.

19 / THE TWO JOBS

Every ad has two jobs.

What people actually look at on these platforms is news and gossip. Not your logo. Not your mission statement.

Every year Meta publishes a report on the most-viewed content on the platform. It's the same thing every year. News, local updates, and gossip. That's what people are there for. Not your brand video.

You might be thinking "I'm not turning my plumbing company into a tabloid." Fair. But don't hate the player, hate the game. We're not going to change what people want to look at. We're going to put your business in the stream that already exists.

JOB 1

Give them something worth looking at

Real news, a real finding, something useful. "Here's what we found under 40 roofs in your neighborhood this summer." That's content. People stop for content.

JOB 2

Sell the click

Enough curiosity that more people click yours than the other guys' in the same auction. When that happens, Meta rewards you with cheaper placements and better people.

Notice what's not on the list. Selling the job. That happens on the page and on the phone. The ad's only job is to get the right person to stop and click.

Real means real. A finding you can back up. Never a fake news headline, a fake story, or a made-up review. It works for a week and then it costs you the account and the trust.

DO THIS NOW

Write down three things you found on jobs this month that a customer would want to know.

20 / THE AD SKELETON

The anatomy of an ad that works.

Every winning ad we run has the same bones. Learn them.



Your company
Sponsored

Most people in {city} don't find out until the ceiling stain shows up. Here's what we look for first...



The 3 things we check before we quote a roof

Took us 10 years to get the list down to three

Learn more

1. Scroll-stopping image

The pattern interrupt. The first thing the eye lands on. Real photo, something slightly off.

2. Headline

Curiosity plus one specific benefit, in one line.

3. Lead-in

The first one or two lines above "See more." The most overlooked part of the whole ad.

4. Link description

The small text under the image. Most people leave it blank. It's free curiosity space.

5. Body copy

The long part. Yes, long beats short, when it's interesting.

6. Non-threatening button

"Learn more." Not "Book now." Not "Get a quote." We'll explain.

DO THIS NOW Pull up your best ad. Mark which of the six it has. Most have two.

Three things, every time.

Before an ad goes live, it answers yes to all three. Two out of three is average. One is dead on arrival.

1

Does it stop the scroll?

Is there something in the picture that makes the brain go "wait, what's that?" for half a second? A real photo of a real problem does it. A stock photo of a guy in a polo doesn't.

2

Does it open a question?

Is there something in the headline and the picture that a person can only answer by clicking? "The one thing every inspector misses" opens a question. "Quality roofing since 1998" doesn't.

3

Does it promise one specific thing to one specific person?

Will the right person read it and think "that's me, I want that"? "Homeowners in {city}" plus "before the summer storms" plus a number does it.

A word on "clickbait"

Most people hear clickbait and think it's a dirty word. Break it down. Bait for a click. That's exactly what Meta wants, people clicking and engaging. The opposite of clickbait is an ad nobody wants to click, and Meta punishes that with worse placements and higher costs.

What you don't want is clickbait with no benefit. The wrong people click, and the algorithm has no idea who to find more of. You want the bait, and you want it aimed at your exact customer.

DO THIS NOW Score your current ads one to three. Rewrite anything under three.

21 / HEADLINES

Don't write headlines from a blank page.

You don't need to be a copywriter. You need to pay attention to what already makes people stop.

Every headline that works on these platforms is a remix of a shape that already works. The local news page. The neighborhood Facebook group. The "you won't believe what this inspector found" post that your aunt shared. Read thirty of them, then write yours.

The levers

Curiosity

The strongest one. Always pull it.

Specific benefit

"Cuts your cooling bill about \$40 a month," not "saves energy."

Fear of loss

What it costs them to ignore this. A roof leak in month three costs more than the inspection in month one.

Specificity

"3 things." "11 homes on your street." "\$1,200." Numbers get believed. Vague gets ignored.

Self-interest

Cooler house, cleaner truck, faster shipments, clearer skin. What they get, not what you do.

Local

The city. The neighborhood. The storm last week. Local is the cheapest pattern interrupt there is.

DOUBTED

"We'll help you get more leads."
"Quality AC repair you can trust."

BELIEVED

"49 leads in 30 days at \$17.70 each."
"The \$90 AC fix that most techs in {city} skip."

DO THIS NOW

Write ten headlines for one service. Pick the two you would stop for.

21 / HEADLINES

Swipe the shape. Change the words.

You're not stealing. You're borrowing a structure that billions of views already proved.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

ORIGINAL	"Secret way to find out who called you without using Google"
ADAPTED	"The way to find out what your roof is actually worth before the adjuster shows up"
ORIGINAL	"Nurse explains the three words most people say before they die"
ADAPTED	"Mechanic explains the three sounds most people ignore before the transmission goes"
ORIGINAL	"Homeowners stunned after spotting detail on their water bill"
ADAPTED	"{City} homeowners surprised by what's hiding in their attic insulation"

The shape does the work. The words make it yours and make it true. If you can't back the adapted line up with something real from your jobs, don't run it. Pick a different shape.

DO THIS NOW Save a folder of twenty headlines you stopped for. Add to it every week.

22 / PATTERN INTERRUPTS

Win the scroll.

The picture stops the thumb. The headline closes the deal. Half a second is all you need.

Things that stop the scroll for a local business

- **A raw phone photo** from a job site. It doesn't look like an ad, so it doesn't get skipped like one.
- **The problem itself.** The rusted water heater. The hail damage. The before, next to the after.
- **A red circle or an arrow** drawn on a real photo pointing at one thing. Feels like somebody showing you a secret.
- **A text message screenshot.** A real customer text (with permission) next to a photo of the job. The brain reads texts as one-to-one, not as advertising.
- **A face with a real expression.** Your tech grimacing at what he found. Not a thumbs-up.
- **A map or a chart.** A map of the 40 streets you worked on this year. Implies data. People trust data.
- **One bright thing** in an otherwise plain frame. The copper pipe. The yellow tape measure.

Things that don't

- Stock photos of smiling people in polos.
- Your logo. Your truck wrap by itself. A product on a white background.
- You, doing a thumbs-up.
- Anything that looks like an ad.

DO THIS NOW Go through your phone. Pull the ten ugliest, most real job photos you have. Those are your next ads.

22 / PATTERN INTERRUPTS

Make the ad look like a post. Not an ad.

People have been trained for thirty years to skip ads. Don't fight it. Use it.

Before somebody can buy from you, they have to read. Before they read, they have to not skip. Everything about the ad should look like something a neighbor posted, not something a company paid for.

The burner account trick

If you don't know what "native" looks like in your niche, do this. Make a fresh Facebook or TikTok account. Follow the big pages in your trade, the local news, the neighborhood groups, and a few competitors. Spend twenty minutes liking and reading. Now every time you open that account, the algorithm shows you what's actually working in your market, sorted by what people engage with.

That's your swipe file. Make your ads look like that.

Even better

If you've posted something in the last six months that got unusual engagement, a job photo, a before and after, a rant about a bad install you fixed, take it. Don't reinvent it. Put it in Ads Manager, write a headline and a lead-in, and run it. A post that already worked for free is the cheapest ad test there is.

DO THIS NOW Find your best organic post from the last six months. Turn it into an ad this week.

23 / FORMATS

Statics first. Video second.

A quick word on pictures versus video before the formats.

In a perfect world you'd put out a new video every week. Most owners can't. Even with somebody helping, video is slow. Shoot it, edit it, redo it, and by the time it's done the season changed.

A static image ad? You can make ten in an afternoon on your phone.

And Meta's system is hungry. It needs fresh ads or the old ones wear out. Across the accounts we run, a handful of plain, native-looking image ads regularly do as well as or better than the polished video, at a fraction of the effort.

The takeaway isn't "video is dead." It's "don't let video be your bottleneck."

Run both if you can. If you can only do one, do the images, all day. Ten to fifteen image ads per launch across the formats on the next pages and you'll never run dry.

When you do shoot video, keep it to the phone. You, on a job, talking for 45 seconds about the one thing you found. No intro, no music, no logo animation. The same rule applies: it has to look like a post, not an ad.

DO THIS NOW

Block two hours this week to make ten image ads from real job photos.

23 / FORMATS

Six formats we cycle through.

Every account we run rotates these. Mix them. Meta gets bored of one.

1 • THE RAW NATIVE

A phone photo that doesn't look like an ad

You and your crew on a job. Two or three people in frame reads as a social post. Meta serves it like content.

2 • THE TEXT MOCKUP

A screenshot of a customer text

"Hey, the AC's been running great since you came out, thank you" next to a photo of the unit. Real text, with permission. Reads as personal.

3 • THE LOCAL UPDATE

Looks like a neighborhood news post

"Heads up, {neighborhood}: here's what the hail did to 14 roofs on {street} last week." Real finding, real photos. The most reliable format we run. Keep it honest and keep it to a third of your mix.

4 • THE HIGHLIGHT

A real photo with a red circle or arrow

Pointing at the crack, the corrosion, the thing the last guy missed. Feels hand-drawn and urgent.

5 • THE SOCIAL POST

Main photo plus a small inset photo

The format every local news page uses. Before in the corner, after in the main frame. Headline underneath in plain words.

6 • THE REVEAL

A map, chart, or screenshot plus a teaser

"We mapped every job we did in {city} this year. One ZIP code had 3x the water heater failures." Data gets trusted.

Format 3 is a real update about real work. Never a fake news headline or a made-up event. The honest version works, and you get to keep the account.

DO THIS NOW Make at least one ad in four of the six formats before your next launch.

24 / THE LEAD-IN

The two lines everybody wastes.

The lead-in is the first one to three lines of copy, the part above "See more." It is the single most overlooked piece of the ad.

Most owners put a tagline there. Or "Attention homeowners!" Or they repeat the headline. All three say "this is an ad" and the thumb keeps moving.

We've changed nothing else about an ad, same photo, same headline, same body, and watched the cost per lead move a lot by rewriting just these two lines.

What a good lead-in does

- Continues the curiosity from the headline instead of restating it.
- Sounds like a person talking. "Most people don't find out until..."
- Introduces one specific, unexpected detail.
- Ends mid-thought, so they have to hit "See more."

BAD LEAD-IN

"Are you a homeowner in {city} who needs a new roof? Then you need to read this!"

GOOD LEAD-IN

"We pulled the shingles off 14 houses on {street} after the storm. Twelve of them had the same thing going on underneath, and it wasn't the hail..."

The first one screams ad. The second one sounds like a post from a guy who was there, and it's specific.

DO THIS NOW

Rewrite the first two lines of your best ad. Change nothing else. Run both for a week.

25 / BODY COPY

Long copy wins. When it is interesting.

Long and boring is worse than short and boring. But long and interesting beats everything.

Write the best ad you can without thinking about length, then cut it hard. Meta allows about 2,200 characters where long copy shows. Use the room, but earn it.

RULE 1	Write like you talk to a customer in the driveway. Fifth-grade reading level. Short words. If you wouldn't say it out loud, don't type it.
RULE 2	Short sentences. Short paragraphs. One or two lines each. People will tell you it breaks the rules from English class. Ignore them. White space gets read.
RULE 3	Write to one person. Not "our customers." You. Not "{Business} offers." We do.
RULE 4	Go easy on "you" and "your." Meta's filters don't love ads that call out personal attributes. "People who..." and "anyone with a..." work just as well.
RULE 5	Lead with what's in it for them. If they can't see it in the first line, they're gone.
RULE 6	Positive beats negative, most of the time. "Keep the house at 72 all summer for about \$40 a month less" beats "Don't let your AC die this summer." Test both. Default to the positive.

DO THIS NOW Paste your ad into a readability checker. If it reads above eighth grade, cut it.

25 / BODY COPY

Specific is believable. Believable gets clicked.

And there is a second reason long copy works that most people never hear.

RULE 7

Add real numbers, real names, real timeframes. "A roofer in {city} went from 2 roofs a month to 8" is a sentence people believe. "We help roofers grow" is noise. Show some personality. Your reader is sick of corporate-speak.

RULE 8

One ad, one angle. Once you've got a headline that works, the picture, the lead-in, the body, and the button all serve that one idea. Don't try to say five things.

RULE 9

Long copy is targeting fuel. Meta reads the copy to decide who sees it. Short copy gives it almost nothing to go on. Long, specific copy, "homeowners in {neighborhood} with a 15-year-old unit," tells it exactly who to find.

SHORT COPY

Small signal. Small pool of people. Meta is guessing.

LONG, SPECIFIC COPY

Big signal. Big pool of the right people. Meta knows who you want.

This is why "short and punchy" loses to "long and interesting" on Meta. Not only because long copy sells better. Because short copy starves the system of the information it needs to find your customer.

DO THIS NOW Add three specific details to your ad body. A number, a street, a timeframe.

26 / THE BUTTON

"Learn more." That's the button.

Not "Book now." Not "Get a quote." Not "Call now." Learn more.

Here's why. The whole ad up to this point has been selling the click, not the job. Then you put a high-pressure button on the end of it and it contradicts everything above it. The person was reading a post, and now it's a sales pitch.

"Learn more" is non-threatening. It promises information, not a commitment. It gets the click. And the click is the only thing the ad is for.

You sell on the page and on the phone. Not in the ad.

One exception for a local business. If the campaign's whole job is phone calls from people with an emergency right now, a call button can be the right move. Test it against "Learn more" to a page with a big phone number on it. Let the cost per booked job decide, not the cost per click.

DO THIS NOW

Switch your prospecting ads to "Learn more." Watch the cost per lead for a week.

27 / ONE-WORD TARGETING

Change one word. Open a new pocket of customers.

Since the ad is the targeting, you put the targeting in the ad.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Take your best ad. Look at the customers who make up most of your revenue. What kind of property, what part of town, what kind of business? Now duplicate the ad and swap one word in the headline or the lead-in.

GENERIC

"Here's what we found under 40 roofs this summer."

ONE WORD SWAPPED

"Here's what we found under 40 roofs in {Westside} this summer."

"...under 40 roofs on 1990s builds..."

"...under 40 roofs on rental properties..."

Same offer. Same photo. One word. Meta reads "rental properties" and goes looking for landlords. You just reached a group the generic ad was never going to find.

Same idea for the picture. If your med spa does well with women in their fifties and also women in their thirties, don't narrow the age in the settings. Run one ad with each in the photo. Meta reads the age off the picture and the copy.

DO THIS NOW

Duplicate your best ad. Swap one word. Change nothing else. Launch. Check in 48 hours.

28 / MORE ADS FROM ONE WINNER

A winner is a seed. Not a finish line.

Most people find one ad that works, turn everything else off, and ride it until it dies. Then they panic and start over.

Don't do that. Once you've got a winner, that's the DNA. Make more of it.

The workflow

1

Feed the winning ad to an AI tool

The Demand Intelligence software does this for you. Any AI tool works. Just do it.

2

Give it the brief

"Read this ad. You wrote it. Write the next one in the same voice. If we showed 100 people both ads, not one should be able to tell they're by different people."

3

Ask for variants by customer

"Rewrite for a landlord." "Rewrite for a first-time homebuyer." "Rewrite for a fleet manager." The bones stay. The person changes.

4

Body copy first, then headlines, then photo ideas

Twenty to fifty versions. Push them all into one campaign and let Meta pick.

The zombie campaign

Meta will spend on five or ten of them and leave the rest at zero. Don't delete the zeros. Take the ones you still believe in and put them in their own ad set. Meta's first pick isn't always right, and a good ad sometimes never gets an at-bat in a crowded campaign. Give it one. You'll usually find a couple more winners in that batch.

DO THIS NOW

Take your best ad from the last 30 days. Generate 20 variants this week. Launch them together.

29 / THE PAGE

Match the ad to the page.

Most owners spend all their effort on the ad and none on where it goes. That is backwards.

The ad sold a click on one specific promise. The page has to deliver that same promise inside half a second. The headline on the page and the headline on the ad should match, word for word or close to it. Break that trail and you lose half the clicks before they read anything.

The scent test

- 1 Open your top three ads. Click them like a customer would.
- 2 Read the first line on the page.
- 3 Same words? Same promise? Same picture? If not, fix it today.

Meta is the cheapest split test you'll ever get

Testing a headline on your website takes thousands of visitors to mean anything. On Meta, a headline gets tens of thousands of views for pocket change. So run twenty headline variants on the ads. Let Meta find the winner. Then put the winning headline on the page, the top of the form, and the first line of your follow-up text. The page converts better because the ad already proved the words.

Keep at least one test running at all times. Owners will haggle a vendor for \$40 a month and then go to bed with zero tests running on the biggest line item they have, which is what it costs to get a customer.

DO THIS NOW Fix every page whose headline doesn't match its ad. Then set a Monday reminder: "Is a test running?"

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

Structure only matters after you have a winner.

If the ad is bad, no setup on earth saves it. You can't structure your way out of a boring ad.

So if you skipped straight here looking for the setup hack, go back. Read the ad pages. Do them. Then come back.

The ad is the signal. The account is the amplifier. A weak signal through a great amplifier is still weak.

But once you've got an ad that stops thumbs and gets clicks, the structure matters a lot. The right setup can squeeze noticeably more out of the exact same ad, stop you wasting money on bad days, and let you turn the budget up without the whole thing falling apart.

Two campaigns. That's it.

LAUNCH

Where every new ad goes first

Purpose: test. One ad set per 10 to 20 ads.
Mix the formats, don't group them.
Campaign budget, with a cost cap. The campaign sorts winners from losers.

SCALE

Where the winners get amplified

Purpose: squeeze every lead out of what works. Winners get copied here. One ad set per landing page or offer. Campaign budget, cost cap, bigger ceiling.

No more "prospecting vs retargeting." No more interest-stack campaigns. One service or offer, two campaigns.

DO THIS NOW

Draw your account on paper. If there are more than two campaigns per offer, ask why.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

The settings that apply to everything.

Set these once on both campaigns and stop fiddling.

GOAL

Leads. A form fill or a call, tracked. Not clicks, not "engagement," not video views. You can't pay a crew with video views.

AUDIENCE

Broad, inside your service area. Advantage+ audience. No interest stacks, no lookalikes. Your real service radius is the only line you draw. The ad does the rest of the targeting. When you have the Part 2 list, upload it as a custom audience and run it alongside broad.

AGE AND GENDER

Everybody. Even if your customer is "women 40 plus," launch broad. Narrowing handicaps the system before it learns. Put the 45-year-old in the photo instead. Only narrow if, after two weeks of real spend, the budget is clearly going to a group that never converts.

EXCLUSIONS

Your existing customers, two ways. The pixel audience catches some. The customer list uploaded from your CRM catches the rest. Set up both. Otherwise you're paying to show ads to people who already paid you, and counting their next job as "ad-driven."

PLACEMENTS

Advantage+ placements. Let Meta serve it everywhere. Don't hand-pick.

ATTRIBUTION

7-day click, 1-day engaged view. Not 1-day view. Most "view" conversions are people who were going to call anyway. Your reported numbers will look worse the day you switch. They aren't worse. They're honest.

DO THIS NOW Open each ad set. Check all six. Fix what does not match.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

Bids and budgets.

This is the part most people get wrong, because it feels backwards.

Cost cap, not highest volume

Meta's default is "highest volume." That means it spends your whole daily budget no matter how the day is going. Bad day? Spends it anyway. Great day? Hits the ceiling and stops.

We run a cost cap instead. You tell Meta "only spend if you can get me a lead for about this much." Then it spends less on bad days and more on good days, and only on the ads that are hitting the number.

What number? The one from your numbers worksheet. The most you can pay for a lead and still make money on the job. Set it there. If it won't spend after a few days, nudge it up 10 to 20 percent. If it overspends and the leads are junk, nudge it down. You're not lying to the system. You're calibrating it.

Set the budget higher than you'll spend

With a cost cap, the daily budget is a ceiling, not a target. Meta only spends up to it if it can hit your cost. So set the ceiling at about twice what you expect to spend. That gives it room to go hard on the good days, when the right people are online and the leads are cheap. A tight budget caps your best days.

Brand new campaign? Start with a low budget for the first three to five days and make sure the cost cap is actually working. Then raise the ceiling.

Judge a cost cap on a 7 to 14 day average, not day to day. Meta credits a lead to the day it came in, not the day the ad was seen. Monday's spend becomes Wednesday's leads.

DO THIS NOW

Set the cost cap at your real max cost per lead. Set the budget at 2x expected spend.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

Retarget with a different reason. Not more pressure.

For a local business with a real sales cycle, retargeting pays. Done the usual way, it just annoys people.

THE WRONG WAY

Same ad they already saw. Shown again. With a discount on it. Hammered for 30 days. They already said no, and you're saying it louder and cheaper.

THE RIGHT WAY

Ask why they didn't call. There are usually three reasons. Build one campaign for each.

A • OBJECTIONS

Answer the real reasons

"I've been burned by a contractor before." "I don't want a pushy salesman in my house." "Is this going to cost more than they said?" One ad per objection, answered straight.

B • PROOF

Real customers, real results

A carousel of reviews and before-and-afters. Match the proof to the person. Landlords see landlord jobs.

C • DIFFERENT OFFER

A smaller next step

The person who didn't book the full replacement might book the \$90 inspection. Different price, different angle.

Build the audiences first: people who hit your page or engaged with your posts in the last 30 and 180 days. Exclude customers. Then run objections first, proof second, the smaller offer third.

Skip all of this for a low-ticket, one-visit service. Broad targeting now retargets better than you can by hand for those. Retargeting earns its keep when a job is worth real money and people take a while to decide.

DO THIS NOW

Write down the three reasons people don't book with you. Those are your three retargeting ads.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

The launch checklist.

Every time a new round of ads goes out, run this.

BEFORE YOU LAUNCH

DONE

10 to 20 new ads across at least four formats

☐

Every ad passes all three: stops the scroll, opens a question, promises one specific thing

☐

Headlines borrowed from a shape that already works, and true

☐

Lead-in continues the headline and ends mid-thought. Not a tagline.

☐

Body copy under 2,200 characters, reads like a driveway conversation

☐

"Learn more" button

☐

Page headline matches the ad headline

☐

Launched in Launch, not Scale

☐

Broad audience inside the service area. Customer list excluded, both ways.

☐

7-day click, 1-day engaged view attribution

☐

Cost cap set at your real max cost per lead

☐

Low budget for the first 3 to 5 days

☐

Every lead routes to a phone and a person inside 5 minutes

☐

DO THIS NOW

Print this page. Tape it next to the computer.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

When an ad wins. When an ad dies.

A winner is any ad Meta chooses to put real budget on. Not the one with the best click rate. The platform sees signals you don't.

When it wins

- Leave the original on in Launch. Don't pause it. The learning is tied to that ad.
- Copy it into every ad set in Scale, one per page or offer.
- Feed it to the variant workflow. Twenty to fifty versions back into Launch.
- Clone it with the one-word swap. Neighborhood, property type, customer type.
- Raise the Scale budget ceiling to 2x expected spend. Wait a week before you touch the cost cap.

Before you kill one that's slowing down, ask three questions

1

Is it the reporting lag?

Leads get credited to the day they came in. Wait three more days.

2

Is everything slowing down?

Then it's the season, the costs, or the page. Fix that, not the ad.

3

Is it worn out?

Frequency over 3? Don't kill it. Run it through the variant workflow and ship 20 fresh versions before it dies. The idea still works. The surface needs to change.

Killing a winning ad after two bad days is one of the most expensive mistakes we see. Look at the 7-day number. Most "dead" ads come back by day five.

DO THIS NOW Check frequency on your top ad. If it is over 3, start the variants today.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

Track the number that pays the crew.

This is what separates people who run ads from people who run a business.

Meta's dashboard shows you a number. Your bank account shows you a different number. Both are true. If you're optimizing for the dashboard, you can optimize yourself right out of business.

Cost per paid job

Not cost per lead. Not cost per click. Total spend across every channel, divided by jobs that finished and paid. From your job records, not the ad platform.

Net cash, 30 days

What went in. What came back after materials, labor, refunds, and fees. That gap, over a month. It's the only number that pays rent.

Max you can pay per customer

Sit down with your real margins. Figure out the most you can spend to get a customer and still hit your profit. Aim at that, not the cost per lead you got comfortable with two years ago.

The trap

"I tried spending more and the cost per lead went up." Right. That's how scaling works. The question isn't whether the cost per lead went up. It's whether more cash hit the bank this month. Going from \$3,000 a month in ads to \$9,000 at a higher cost per lead is usually the right call if the jobs went from 12 to 30. Pay the crew with the difference.

Numbers day. Block three hours, same day every month. You, the job records, and the bank account. No media buyer, no report. It's not the fun thing on the calendar. It moves the money more than anything else on it.

DO THIS NOW Put a recurring three-hour "Numbers day" on the first Friday of every month.

30 / ACCOUNT STRUCTURE

The most common mistakes.

We see every one of these in accounts that come to us. Check yours.

- **Obsessing over settings instead of the ad.** Backwards. Fix the ad first.
- **Ads that look like ads.** Logo, brand colors, stock photo. Dead on arrival.
- **"Book now" buttons on cold traffic.** Pressure breaks the flow. Learn more.
- **Not excluding your customer list.** You're paying to advertise to people who already paid you.
- **1-day view attribution.** Fluff in the report. Every decision after it is off.
- **Narrowing the audience by hand.** Let it run broad inside your area. Put the targeting in the ad.
- **Budget equal to expected spend.** Caps your best days. Set the ceiling at 2x.
- **Killing winners after two bad days.** Look at seven. Make variants before you kill anything.
- **Treating long copy as the enemy.** Long and interesting wins, and it feeds the targeting.
- **Riding one winner until it dies.** Clone it. Swap words. Make variants. Dozens of ads from one.
- **Optimizing for the dashboard instead of the bank.** Cost per paid job and net cash grow a business. Cost per lead grows a screenshot.
- **Running ads to a phone nobody answers.** The most expensive one on this list. Five minutes. Every lead. Or don't run the ads.

The tactics on these pages will change. Buttons get renamed, settings move. The principles don't. The ad is the lever. The ad is the targeting. People stop for real things. Net cash is the only number that pays anybody.

DO THIS NOW Count how many of the twelve you are doing right now. Fix the top one this week.

04

Your 90 days.

What to do first, what to do next, and the worksheets to do it with.

31 / THE PLAN

Build it in three steps.

Do the next phase when the first one actually works. Not when the calendar says so.

DAYS 1 TO 30

Fix the basics

Test tracking and lead routing. Fix the phone, the form, and the 5-minute follow-up. Clean up the offer, the website, and the Google profile. Get the CRM honest.

DAYS 31 TO 60

Get more good leads

Pull your buying-signal list. Build the service pages. Ask every customer for a review. Launch one funded ad test from Part 3 to that list.

DAYS 61 TO 90

Keep what works

Reach the right past customers. Add service reminders. Scale the winning ad with the Launch and Scale setup. Review jobs, costs, and crew room.

Don't raise spend because the date changed. Raise it when the full path works, from ad to paid job, and the crew can actually do the work that comes in.

When you pray for rain, you have to deal with the mud. If the leads double and you can't answer the phone or do the jobs, that's not growth, that's a bad month with more expensive reviews.

DO THIS NOW Start with phase one. Put the work on the calendar with names next to it.

31 / THE PLAN

Your first week.

One small task a day gets the whole thing moving.

1

Day 1

Pull ten leads. Find the first leak.

2

Day 2

Test the phone, the form, and the chat. Time the response.

3

Day 3

Give every open lead an owner and a dated next task.

4

Day 4

Go through old quotes. Reply to every open lead.

5

Day 5

Check one finished job's revenue and real costs.

A broken contact path gets fixed the day you find it, not on day 5. Everything else can wait its turn.

DO THIS NOW Pick the day you start.

32 / WORKSHEETS

Your one-fix worksheet.

Turn an idea into a task with a name and a date on it.

THE SERVICE WE WANT TO GROW

THE STEP WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

WHAT THE RECORDS SHOW

THE ONE CHANGE WE WILL MAKE

WHO OWNS IT, AND THE DUE DATE

WHAT WE WILL COUNT TO CHECK IT WORKED

Use a clear task. "Fix the form alert by Friday." Then test it. Save what changed and what you learned, because you will forget by next month.

DO THIS NOW Fill this out with the person who owns the work.

32 / WORKSHEETS

Your numbers worksheet.

One service, one time period. Write "not sure" where you don't know.
That's an answer too.

AVERAGE JOB VALUE

Money from finished jobs ÷ finished jobs

GROSS PROFIT PER JOB

Revenue minus direct job costs

COST PER LEAD

Cost to win leads ÷ number of leads

COST PER BOOKING

Same cost ÷ number of bookings

COST PER NEW CUSTOMER

Same cost ÷ new customers with finished jobs

MOST YOU CAN PAY FOR A LEAD

Gross profit per job × your close rate, minus the margin you need

NEXT MONTH'S JOB GOAL AND CREW ROOM

DO THIS NOW Use real numbers. This page is the first thing we go over on a call.

32 / WORKSHEETS

Your ad worksheet.

Fill this out before you build the ad. If a box is empty, the ad isn't ready.

WHO IS IT FOR (ONE PERSON, NOT A GROUP)

THE BUYING SIGNAL THEY JUST GAVE

THE PATTERN INTERRUPT (WHAT'S IN THE PICTURE)

THE HEADLINE (CURIOSITY PLUS ONE SPECIFIC BENEFIT)

THE LEAD-IN (FIRST TWO LINES, ENDS MID-THOUGHT)

THE PAGE IT GOES TO (HEADLINE MATCHES THE AD)

WHAT A LEAD FROM THIS AD CAN COST (FROM THE NUMBERS WORKSHEET)

DO THIS NOW Build ten of these before you launch one.

YOUR NEXT STEP

You have the playbook.

Start with one fix. Build from there.

Do it with your team

Use the worksheets. Fix one handoff at a time. Pull your own list with the Demand Intelligence software and run the ads yourself.

Build it with Dead River

We find the people looking, build the ads and the page, run the follow-up, and you answer the phone. \$50,000 in new revenue in 45 to 60 days, or your money back, plus \$500 for wasting your time.

Your side of the guarantee

- Keep \$3,000 a month in ad spend funded, and don't lower it.
- Get back to every lead within 5 minutes.
- Log every lead in the CRM so we're both looking at the same numbers.
- Give it the full 60 days.

That's it. No fine print. On the call we go over what a customer is worth to you and what your average ticket is, and we figure out together whether this is a fit before anybody talks about price.

Book a free 30-minute strategy session at deadrivermanagement.com

Or call or text Brandon at (915) 228-3054. brandon@deadrivermanagement.com

DO THIS NOW Keep one promise: give every customer a clear next step.